Ordering and Supplies

How to get what you need, and what never to order yourself

Marisol Vega, Lab Manager (Keller 414, x4412, mvega@westbrook.edu) · Updated 2 September 2026

Before you order anything, check whether we already have it: the freezer, antibody and cell-line inventories (all on `okafor-nas`), the shared shelves in 414, and the stockroom. About a third of the order requests I receive are for things already in the lab.

1. How to order

1. Add a row to the **"Okafor Lab Orders 2026" spreadsheet** (link pinned in #orders). Fill in: date, your name, item, vendor, catalogue number, quantity, unit price, total, and whether it is urgent. I fill in the grant/chartstring column; leave it blank.
2. Approval depends on the total for the order:

Order total	Approval
Under $250	Marisol approves routine items and places the order.
$250 to $1,999	**PI approval required.** I flag it for Adaeze, who marks "Approved" in the spreadsheet (usually within two working days).
$2,000 or more; any equipment; service contracts; software licences	**Talk to Adaeze first.** I then get a quote and go through Westbrook Procurement, which takes 2–4 weeks.

- **Order days.** I place orders on Tuesdays and Thursdays by noon. Rows added by 5 pm the day before make that day's order.
- **Urgent orders.** Mark the row "Urgent" and message me on Slack. Next-day shipping needs a reason, because it costs the lab a lot.
- **Receiving.** Packages arrive at 414. I log them and put cold items away (4 °C, -20 °C, -80 °C) the same day; I will message you if you need to collect something.
- **Where we order from.** Mostly Fisher Scientific, Sigma-Aldrich and VWR, through Westbrook's purchasing system. Please give me the catalogue number from the vendor you found, and I will check for a cheaper equivalent.
- **Personal cards.** Do not buy lab supplies on a personal card expecting reimbursement. Purchases are reimbursed only if I approved them in writing beforehand.

2. The MCB stockroom

Where: Keller Hall basement, room B12.
Hours: Monday to Friday, 8:30 am to 5:00 pm. Closed weekends and university holidays. (The hours changed in January 2026; the stockroom used to close at 6:00 pm.)
How to pay: give your name and the lab account ("Okafor Lab, OKA-2210") and sign the charge slip.

What it carries: gloves, pipette tips, tubes, serological pipettes, paper towels, common salts and buffer components, 95% and 100% ethanol (signed out), and **dry ice, sold by the kilogram until closing**. Bring your own foam cooler for dry ice. For dry ice outside stockroom hours, see *After Hours and Special Materials*.

3. Oligonucleotides

Order standard DNA oligos from the **Westbrook Genomics & Oligo Core** (Sato Center, room 010) through the core's online order form. Use the lab chartstring pinned in #orders. Standard desalted oligos arrive the next working day in the core's pick-up fridge. **Do not order standard oligos directly from a vendor**: the core's prices are lower and it is university policy. For modified oligos or gene fragments the core does not offer, use the orders spreadsheet.

4. Cell lines

- Cell lines come from the **lab's frozen stocks**, never from another lab's incubator. Working stocks are in **Dewar 2** in 416; master stocks are in Dewar 1 and are handled only with Tomasz.
- The inventory is `okafor-nas/admin/inventory/cell_lines.xlsx`. Record every vial you take (date, your name, box and position) *before* you walk away from the dewar.
- **Never take the last two vials of any line from Dewar 2.** Tell Mei-Ling Zhou instead, and she will expand and re-freeze it.
- Use cells within 20 passages of thawing. Mei-Ling runs mycoplasma tests in the first week of every month. Untested lines live only in the quarantine incubator (Inc-4) and cabinet (BSC-3).
- **New cell lines from outside the lab** need a material transfer agreement (Marisol) *and* an amendment to the biosafety registration (Tomasz and Adaeze) *before* they arrive, plus authentication and a mycoplasma test on arrival.

5. Media and serum

- Complete DMEM and complete RPMI are **prepared every Monday by the person on media-prep duty** (see the rota in *Who Does What*). Bottles are on the "Media" shelf of the 413 fridge. Take one bottle at a time, and write your initials and the date you opened it on the label. Bottles expire four weeks after preparation.
- Specialised media (serum-free, selection media, etc.) you make yourself. Label them fully.
- **FBS** is lot-tested by Mei-Ling, and 50 mL aliquots are in the -20 °C freezer in 413. Do not order serum yourself: the lot matters.

6. Antibodies

- Check the antibody inventory (`okafor-nas/admin/inventory/antibodies.xlsx`) before ordering. Many antibodies are shared.

- Storage: the antibody rack in the 416A cold room (4 °C), or boxes Ab-1 to Ab-6 in the -20 °C freezer in 415, as the inventory says.
- Record the clone, lot number and dilution in your ELN entry. If less than 20 µL is left, add a reorder row to the orders spreadsheet. Add new antibodies to the inventory the day they arrive.

7. Shared stock solutions

PBS (10×), Tris buffers, TAE/TBE and similar stocks are made in the lab. The rule is simple: **if you finish it, you make the next bottle.** Recipes are in `okafor-nas/protocols/buffers/`.

8. Never order these yourself

Always go through Marisol, and in some cases Tomasz or EHS as well:

- **Compressed gas cylinders** (CO_2 for the incubators, nitrogen) and **liquid nitrogen deliveries**: ordered from Airgas by Marisol, with EHS rules for cylinder handling.
- **Chemicals on Westbrook's Restricted Chemicals List** (highly toxic, pyrophoric or explosive substances): EHS approval first.
- **DEA-controlled substances**: the lab holds no DEA registration.
- **Radioactive materials**: the lab has no authorisation.
- **Live animals**: only through the vivarium, under the animal protocol.
- **Cell lines, plasmids, antibodies or any biological material from another lab or institution**: MTA and biosafety review first (Section 4).
- **Anything that ships on dry ice, and all outgoing shipments**: Marisol handles them, as these are regulated shipments.
- **Equipment, or anything costing $2,000 or more**; service contracts; software.